

Not All GenAI Disclosures Are Alike: How the Stage of GenAI Involvement Shapes Purchase Intention for Digital Games

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ABSTRACT

Generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) is increasingly used in digital game development, and disclosures on digital platforms make such use more visible to players. Prior research offers conflicting predictions regarding how users respond to such disclosure. Research on AI-generated products suggests that disclosure can reduce valuation because it weakens source-related beliefs tied to human creation. Research on games as interactive hedonic systems, however, suggests that players also evaluate games in terms of the experience they expect during play. Building on these perspectives, this study conceptualizes GenAI disclosure as the focal independent variable and proposes two pathways through which disclosure influences players' purchase intention. First, GenAI disclosure decreases perceived effort, which lowers purchase intention. Second, GenAI disclosure can increase perceived novelty, which raises purchase intention, but this positive pathway depends on the stage of GenAI involvement described by the disclosure. Specifically, this positive effect is stronger under during-interaction involvement than under pre-interaction involvement. We test the model using a scenario-based online experiment in the context of digital games. The results show that GenAI disclosure reduces perceived effort relative to no disclosure, while its positive effect on perceived novelty emerges primarily when GenAI is described as contributing during gameplay rather than before gameplay. Willingness to pay is included as a supplementary outcome and shows directionally similar but weaker patterns. This study extends GenAI disclosure research to digital games and shows that the effect of disclosure depends not only on whether GenAI use is disclosed, but also on the stage of involvement described by that disclosure.

Keywords: GenAI disclosure, digital games, purchase intention, willingness to pay, perceived effort, perceived novelty.

INTRODUCTION

Digital games are one of the most important categories of digital products and a major source of platform-based revenue, especially in platform-based and free-to-play markets that monetize sustained participation and in-game consumption (Hamari & Keronen, 2017; Wang et al., 2022; Hussain et al., 2025). At the same time, generative artificial intelligence is increasingly used in game development to create dialogue, art assets, world content, quests, and other game elements (Ashby et al., 2023; Gallotta et al., 2024). As platform governance and public scrutiny make AI use more visible, players are increasingly exposed to explicit disclosures that a game uses GenAI, whether in product descriptions, development notes, or platform-level labeling practices (Rix et al., 2025; Sikhondze et al., 2025). Yet how such disclosure affects players' willingness to purchase a game remains unclear.

Prior literature offers conflicting implications. On the one hand, recent studies on AI-generated products suggest that disclosure often reduces users' valuation of AI-created outputs, particularly in creative contexts where users care about human creation and related forms of value (Gu & Li, 2022; Magni et al., 2024; Rix et al., 2025; Sikhondze et al., 2025). This pattern is consistent with work on the handmade effect and the algorithm discount, which shows that consumers often prefer human-created over algorithm-created outputs and may assign lower value to products when algorithmic creation becomes salient (Fuchs et al., 2015; Rix et al., 2025). These findings imply that if players learn a game uses GenAI, they may be less willing to purchase it because the game appears to embody less human effort.

On the other hand, this implication may not fully apply to digital games. Unlike relatively static digital products such as wall art or news articles, games are interactive hedonic systems whose value unfolds during use rather than through a one-time judgment of a finished artifact (van der Heijden, 2004; Lin & Bhattacharjee, 2010; Wu & Holsapple, 2014). For that reason, GenAI disclosure in games may do more than indicate how the product was made. It may also shape what players expect from the game during play. This possibility is especially relevant in games because interactivity is partly defined by the extent to which the system reacts contingently and meaningfully to player input. In this sense, GenAI may function not only as a production technology but also as an interaction-enabling technology, for example by supporting more adaptive dialogue,

event variation, or context-sensitive world reactions during play (Ashby et al., 2023; Gallotta et al., 2024). At the same time, disclosure of GenAI use may also function as a cue of technological newness. Prior research on IT innovation adoption suggests that perceived novelty, defined as the extent to which a technology is perceived as new and exciting, can play a meaningful role in shaping adoption-related judgments (Wells et al., 2010). In the game context, a disclosure of GenAI use may therefore increase the extent to which a focal game is perceived as technologically distinctive relative to more conventional digital games.

This tension reveals a research gap. Existing GenAI disclosure research has largely treated disclosure as a source-related cue that reveals AI involvement in creation (Rix et al., 2025; Sikhondze et al., 2025). In games, however, disclosure may also indicate when that involvement becomes relevant to the player experience. More generally, this concerns whether GenAI is described as contributing before or during interaction. A disclosure may describe GenAI as contributing before gameplay begins, such as in generating parts of the game's content. It may instead describe GenAI as contributing during gameplay, such as in dialogue, events, or world interactions. This distinction should matter because it changes the inferences players draw from the GenAI disclosure.

To address this gap, this study draws on two complementary streams of research. The first examines how AI disclosure shapes users' valuation of creative products by making nonhuman creation salient. The second emphasizes that digital games are evaluated not only as created artifacts but also in terms of the experience they are expected to provide during use. Bringing these perspectives together, we argue that GenAI disclosure in games can activate two opposing pathways, a negative pathway through reduced perceived effort and a positive pathway through perceived novelty.

This study addresses the following research question:

RQ: *How does GenAI disclosure influence players' purchase intention for digital games, and through what mechanisms does this effect emerge?*

This study contributes in two ways. First, it extends GenAI disclosure research from relatively static digital products to digital games, an economically important product category whose evaluation depends on both creative production and anticipated interaction. Second, it shows that disclosure is not a unitary cue. Its effect depends partly on the stage of GenAI involvement described by the disclosure.

CONCEPTUAL BACKGROUND

GenAI Disclosure and Creative Product Valuation

As GenAI becomes more prevalent in digital production, disclosure has become an important cue through which users interpret products. Recent research shows that people often respond less favorably to AI-generated products than to human-generated ones, especially in creative domains (Gu & Li, 2022; Magni et al., 2024; Rix et al., 2025; Sikhondze et al., 2025). Research on AI-generated products further suggests that such responses are shaped by beliefs tied to human creation and product value. Rix et al. (2025) show that consumers discount algorithm-created digital products because they attribute less love, effort, and quality to them. Sikhondze et al. (2025) show that disclosure can alter downstream valuation through psychological value. More broadly, work on handmade and symbolic products shows that valuation depends not only on observable output quality but also on whether a product is perceived to embody meaningful human contribution (Fuchs et al., 2015; Kreuzbauer et al., 2015; Newman & Bloom, 2012). Related research further suggests that consumers rely on cues of human authorship, authenticity, and intentionality when evaluating creative outputs, even when observable output characteristics are similar (Magni et al., 2024).

This literature suggests that AI disclosure changes what a product is taken to represent. Rather than seeing the product as embodying substantial human work, users may instead see it as the output of algorithmic generation. In the game context, such a reaction should be especially relevant because games are both digital products and creative works.

Digital Games as Interactive Hedonic Systems

Digital games differ from many products examined in prior GenAI disclosure research because they are not evaluated only as completed outputs. Games are interactive hedonic systems, and their value depends heavily on the experience they are expected to provide during play (van der Heijden, 2004; Hsu & Lu, 2004; Lin & Bhattacharjee, 2010; Wu & Holsapple, 2014). In this context, players evaluate not only how a game was made, but also what it may do during use.

In games, the same disclosure may have different implications depending on whether GenAI is presented as relevant before play or during play. That distinction should shape how players interpret the disclosed AI involvement. More specifically, when GenAI is framed as operating during gameplay, players may more readily associate it with adaptive interaction, such as dynamic dialogue, personalized events, or responsive world behavior. Thus, in digital games, GenAI disclosure may serve not only as a source-related cue about authorship but also as an experiential cue about likely responsiveness during use. At the same time, because GenAI is widely associated with emerging digital innovation, such disclosure may increase the extent to which the game appears new, technologically distinctive, and worth exploring. This is consistent with prior work suggesting that perceived novelty can act as a salient affective belief in IT innovation adoption (Wells et al., 2010).

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK AND HYPOTHESES

GenAI Disclosure and the Negative Pathway through Perceived Effort

Research on AI-generated products suggests that disclosure of AI involvement can reduce valuation by weakening source-related beliefs tied to human creation. Existing research shows that users react negatively when AI involvement lowers the extent to which a product is believed to embody human input, especially in creative contexts (Rix et al., 2025; Sikhondze et al., 2025). Among these beliefs, perceived effort is especially relevant because creative products are often valued partly for the human work believed to be invested in them (Fuchs et al., 2015; Rix et al., 2025).

This logic should extend to digital games. Games involve narrative design, visual design, and world-building, all of which players may associate with substantial human creative labor. When GenAI use is disclosed, players may infer that less human effort was required to create the game. We therefore define perceived effort as the extent to which a player believes that substantial human effort was invested in creating the focal game.

Accordingly, relative to no disclosure, GenAI disclosure should decrease perceived effort.

H1: GenAI disclosure decreases perceived effort.

Perceived effort should in turn increase purchase intention. Prior literature suggests that products perceived to embody greater human effort are valued more highly, particularly in creative contexts (Fuchs et al., 2015; Rix et al., 2025). In the game context, a game perceived as reflecting greater human effort should be more attractive as a purchase option.

We define purchase intention as the extent to which a player is willing to purchase the focal digital game after viewing its product page.

Thus, we propose:

H2: Perceived effort positively influences purchase intention.

Taken together, these arguments imply a negative indirect effect of GenAI disclosure on purchase intention through perceived effort.

GenAI Disclosure and the Positive Pathway through Perceived Novelty

GenAI disclosure may also shape how technologically novel the game appears. We define perceived novelty as the extent to which a player perceives the focal game as a new and exciting technological offering relative to more conventional digital games. Prior research suggests that perceived novelty is a salient affective belief in IT adoption and can positively influence users' evaluation and adoption of new technologies (Wells et al., 2010). In consumer technology contexts, perceived novelty has also been shown to encourage usage and continuance intention (Yang & Lin, 2017; Fazal-e-Hasan et al., 2021; Wolf & Maier, 2024).

Relative to no disclosure, GenAI disclosure may increase perceived novelty because it highlights the use of an emerging and technologically distinctive capability in the focal game. Once AI use becomes salient, players may infer that the game offers a fresher and more innovative experience than conventional alternatives.

Accordingly, we propose:

H3: GenAI disclosure increases perceived novelty.

However, the strength of this inference should depend on the stage of GenAI involvement described in the disclosure. We define stage of GenAI involvement as whether the disclosure describes GenAI as contributing before or during interaction. Accordingly, pre-interaction involvement refers to disclosure that describes GenAI as contributing before interaction begins, whereas during-interaction involvement refers to disclosure that describes GenAI as contributing during interaction. This distinction concerns the stage of GenAI involvement described by the disclosure, not the timing at which disclosure is presented.

When GenAI is described as contributing before interaction, players may interpret it primarily as a backstage production aid used to support content generation. By contrast, when GenAI is described as contributing during interaction, the innovation is framed as embedded in the gameplay experience itself. In this case, players are more likely to perceive the game as offering a more immediate and visible form of innovation during use. Therefore, during-interaction involvement should generate a stronger perception of novelty than pre-interaction involvement.

Therefore, the effect of GenAI disclosure on perceived novelty should depend on the stage of GenAI involvement.

H4: The stage of GenAI involvement moderates the effect of GenAI disclosure on perceived novelty, such that the positive effect is stronger under during-interaction involvement than under pre-interaction involvement.

Perceived novelty should in turn increase purchase intention. Products and technologies perceived as novel may attract greater curiosity, interest, and willingness to try, especially when they are seen as fresh and exciting alternatives to existing options (Wells et al., 2010). In the digital game context, a game perceived as more novel may therefore be more attractive as a purchase option.

H5: Perceived novelty positively influences purchase intention.

Taken together, these arguments imply a moderated positive indirect effect of GenAI disclosure on purchase intention through perceived novelty.

Supplementary Outcome: Willingness to Pay

In addition to purchase intention, this study includes willingness to pay as a supplementary valuation outcome. Prior GenAI product research frequently uses willingness to pay to capture economic valuation differences under AI-related disclosures (Rix et al., 2025; Sikhondze et al., 2025). If the proposed framework is correct, willingness to pay should show the same directional pattern as purchase intention.

Figure 1 summarizes the research model.

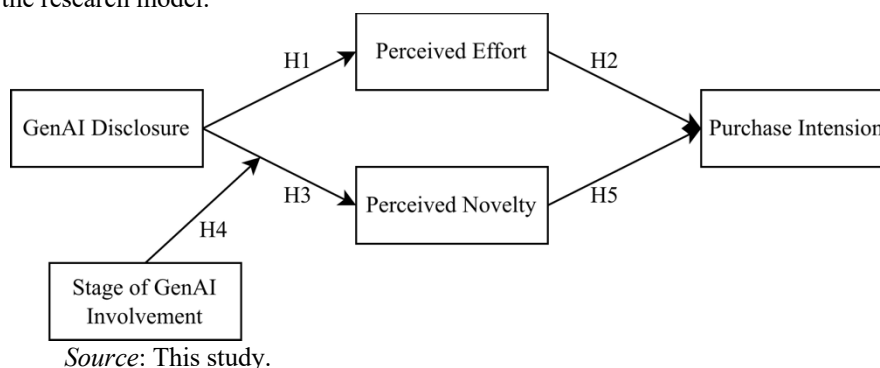


Figure 1: Research model.

RESEARCH METHOD

Research Design

We conducted a scenario-based online experiment in the context of digital games. The study used a between-subjects design with three conditions: no disclosure, GenAI disclosure with pre-interaction involvement, and GenAI disclosure with during-interaction involvement. This design enabled us to test the effect of GenAI disclosure while distinguishing whether the disclosure described GenAI as contributing before or during gameplay.

Stimulus and Procedure

Participants were asked to imagine browsing a digital game platform and encountering a newly released premium narrative role-playing game. All participants viewed the same product page, which included the game title, genre, price, screenshots, and a short description. The disclosure statement varied across conditions.

In the no-disclosure condition, no AI-related statement was presented. In the pre-interaction condition, the product page stated that the game used generative AI to help create parts of its dialogue, story events, and world content before play. In the during-interaction condition, the page stated that the game used generative AI during play in parts of its dialogue, in-game events, and world interactions. In both disclosure conditions, the disclosure appeared before participants evaluated the game.

Participants were recruited from Credamo, a Chinese online survey platform. Only individuals with prior digital game experience were eligible to participate. The final sample consisted of 399 valid responses, with 133 participants in each condition. The sample was 60.2 percent female, 72.7 percent were between 18 and 35 years old, and 85.5 percent held a bachelor's degree or above.

After viewing the product page, participants completed measures of perceived effort, perceived novelty, purchase intention, willingness to pay, manipulation checks, and demographic variables. We also measured openness to new technology, game genre preference, and AI familiarity as control variables.

Measures

All focal constructs were measured on seven-point Likert scales ranging from 1 for strongly disagree to 7 for strongly agree. Internal consistency was satisfactory for the main variables. Cronbach's alpha was .941 for perceived effort, .816 for perceived novelty, and .929 for purchase intention. The alpha values for the control variables were .663 for openness to new technology, .743 for game genre preference, and .704 for AI familiarity.

Perceived effort captured the extent to which respondents believed that substantial human effort had been invested in creating the game. Perceived novelty measured the extent to which the game was seen as new and exciting. Purchase intention assessed respondents' willingness to buy the game. Willingness to pay was measured as the maximum amount, in CNY, that respondents were willing to pay for the focal game.

Analytical Strategy

We first assessed whether the experimental manipulations were successful. We then tested the hypotheses using mean comparisons and regression analyses with the three control variables included. Indirect effects were examined using bootstrap mediation procedures with 5,000 resamples and percentile-based 95 percent confidence intervals. Willingness to pay was analyzed as a supplementary outcome.

RESULTS

Manipulation Checks

The manipulation checks indicated that the experimental manipulations were successful. Participants in the two disclosure conditions reported substantially higher perceived AI use than those in the no-disclosure condition, $F(2, 396) = 339.58$, $p < .001$. In addition, respondents clearly distinguished between the two types of GenAI involvement. Participants in the pre-interaction condition reported significantly stronger agreement that GenAI was used before play, whereas participants in the during-interaction condition reported significantly stronger agreement that GenAI was used during gameplay. These results suggest that participants not only noticed the presence of GenAI disclosure but also correctly interpreted the stage of involvement described by the disclosure.

Main Effects and Indirect Effects

H1 predicted that GenAI disclosure would reduce perceived effort. This prediction was supported. Perceived effort was significantly lower in the disclosure conditions than in the no-disclosure condition, Welch's $t(264.6) = -6.18$, $p < .001$, $d = -0.60$. This effect remained significant after controlling for openness to new technology, game genre preference, and AI familiarity, $\beta = -0.814$, $p < .001$. Perceived effort did not differ significantly between the pre-interaction and during-interaction conditions, suggesting that the negative effect of disclosure on perceived effort was not contingent on the disclosed stage of involvement.

H2 predicted that perceived effort would positively influence purchase intention. This prediction was also supported. Perceived effort was positively correlated with purchase intention, $r = .216$, $p < .001$, and remained a significant positive predictor in the regression model with controls, $\beta = 0.081$, $p = .031$.

Bootstrap mediation analysis showed that disclosure significantly reduced perceived effort, but the indirect effect of disclosure on purchase intention through perceived effort was only marginally significant, indirect effect = -0.065 , 95 percent CI $[-0.146, 0.001]$, $p = .053$. Thus, the component paths were consistent with the proposed negative mechanism, although the indirect effect fell just short of conventional significance.

H3 predicted that GenAI disclosure would increase perceived novelty. This prediction was supported. Perceived novelty was significantly higher in the disclosure conditions than in the no-disclosure condition, Welch's $t(251.0) = 2.88$, $p = .004$, $d = 0.32$. The effect remained significant in the regression analysis with controls, $\beta = 0.288$, $p = .001$.

H4 predicted that the positive effect of disclosure on perceived novelty would be stronger under during-interaction involvement than under pre-interaction involvement. This prediction was supported. Perceived novelty was significantly higher in the during-interaction condition than in the pre-interaction condition, Welch's $t(263.8) = 2.68$, $p = .008$, $d = 0.33$. Additional regressions showed that, relative to no disclosure, the during-interaction condition significantly increased perceived novelty, whereas the pre-interaction condition did not.

H5 predicted that perceived novelty would positively influence purchase intention. This prediction was strongly supported. Perceived novelty was positively correlated with purchase intention, $r = .554$, $p < .001$, and remained a robust predictor in the regression model with controls, $\beta = 0.409$, $p < .001$.

To examine the positive pathway in greater detail, we estimated indirect effects separately for the two disclosure conditions relative to no disclosure. For the pre-interaction condition, the indirect effect through perceived novelty was positive but not significant, 95 percent CI $[-0.016, 0.189]$. For the during-interaction condition, however, the indirect effect through perceived novelty was significant, 95 percent CI $[0.071, 0.303]$. The index of moderated mediation was also significant, index = 0.100 , 95 percent CI $[0.017, 0.197]$. Taken together, these results indicate that the positive indirect effect through perceived novelty emerged primarily when GenAI was described as contributing during gameplay rather than before gameplay.

Supplementary Analysis of Willingness to Pay

The results for willingness to pay were directionally similar but weaker. No significant differences in willingness to pay were observed across conditions. The distribution of willingness to pay was highly skewed, with a median of CNY 68 in all three conditions, matching the listed price of the game.

Bootstrap analyses showed a significant negative indirect effect of disclosure on willingness to pay through perceived effort, 95 percent CI [-13.38, -2.01]. By contrast, the indirect effect through perceived novelty was positive but not significant, 95 percent CI [-1.08, 5.15]. These results suggest that the two mechanisms also operated in opposite directions for economic valuation, although the positive novelty pathway did not translate into a reliable increase in willingness to pay.

DISCUSSION

The findings provide support for the proposed dual-pathway framework. GenAI disclosure reduced perceived effort relative to no disclosure, and perceived effort was positively associated with purchase intention. At the same time, disclosure increased perceived novelty, but this positive effect depended on how the disclosure framed GenAI involvement. When GenAI was described as contributing during gameplay, participants perceived the game as more novel, and this heightened novelty increased purchase intention. When GenAI was described as contributing before gameplay, the positive pathway through novelty was not reliably activated. This pattern suggests that GenAI disclosure does not exert a uniform effect on players' evaluations of digital games.

These findings contribute to research in three ways. First, the study extends GenAI disclosure research to digital games, a context in which users evaluate both the creative origin of the product and the experience it is expected to provide during use. Second, the study refines the concept of disclosure by distinguishing the presence of disclosure from the stage of GenAI involvement described by that disclosure. Third, the results identify perceived novelty as a meaningful positive mechanism in this context, while also showing that disclosure can reduce player evaluations by weakening perceptions of human effort.

The findings also have practical implications. Developers and platforms should not assume that all GenAI disclosures will be interpreted in the same way. Disclosures that frame GenAI as a background production tool may primarily highlight reduced human input. By contrast, disclosures that frame GenAI as part of the gameplay experience may strengthen perceptions of novelty and improve purchase-related responses relative to pre-interaction disclosures. Thus, the wording of disclosure can shape player reactions even when the underlying use of GenAI is similar.

Several limitations should be noted. First, the study focuses on the stage of disclosed GenAI involvement and does not examine other potentially important perceptions, such as quality, authenticity, or realism. Second, the experiment uses a single game genre and a single product page scenario, which may limit generalizability. Third, although several relevant controls were included, future research could examine whether individual differences in AI attitudes or innovation orientation further condition the observed effects.

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APPENDIX A: Experimental Stimuli and Core Measures

A1. Experimental Stimuli

Participants were asked to imagine browsing a digital game platform and encountering a newly released premium narrative role-playing game. All participants viewed the same product page, with the disclosure statement varying by condition.

Common Product Page Content

Game Title: Eternal Echoes

Genre: Premium Narrative Role-Playing Game

Price: CNY 68

Game Description:

Enter a fantasy world filled with ancient ruins, hidden factions, and branching storylines. Explore an unfolding map, interact with distinctive characters, make meaningful choices, and uncover secrets that shape your journey.

Game Features:

- Branching story and character relationship system
- World exploration and quest system
- Multiple dialogue options
- Immersive fantasy setting

Condition 1. No Disclosure

Participants viewed the common product page content only. No AI-related statement was presented.

Condition 2. Pre-Interaction Disclosure

In addition to the common product page content, participants viewed the following disclosure statement:

Disclosure statement:

This game uses generative AI to pre-generate parts of its dialogue, story events, and world content during the development stage. During gameplay, AI does not continue generating this content.

Condition 3. During-Interaction Disclosure

In addition to the common product page content, participants viewed the following disclosure statement:

Disclosure statement:

This game uses generative AI to generate parts of its dialogue, in-game events, and world content in real time during gameplay.

A2. Core Measures

Unless otherwise noted, all items were measured on seven-point Likert scales ranging from 1 for strongly disagree to 7 for strongly agree.

Manipulation Check Items

1. The product page indicated that this game uses generative AI.
2. The product page indicated that generative AI was mainly used to pre-generate parts of the game content during the development stage.

3. The product page indicated that generative AI was mainly used to generate game content in real time during gameplay.

Perceived Effort

1. This game seems to reflect substantial human creative effort.
2. A great deal of human effort seems to have gone into making this game.
3. This game seems carefully crafted by humans.
4. This game seems to embody considerable human labor.

Perceived Novelty

1. This game seems novel.
2. This game seems fresh and exciting.
3. This game represents a novel form of digital game.

Purchase Intention

1. I would consider purchasing this game.
2. My willingness to buy this game is high.
3. The likelihood that I would purchase this game is high.
4. If this game were available now, I would be interested in buying it.

Willingness to Pay

Participants reported the maximum amount, in CNY, that they were willing to pay for the game.